



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Grace Classical School

School Website: <https://graceclassicalschool.com/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because ACCS require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Grace Classical School NC 28540 presents as a small, faith-centered classical school aligned with the Christian classical tradition. Public materials emphasize a Christian worldview, a Trivium-based curriculum, and a partnership with families. The school explicitly frames its mission in terms of truth found in God's Word, formation of character, and a university-style schedule designed to bring structure and accountability to families. Public statements also stress the integration of God's Word throughout instruction and the aim that students become "wise and discerning" lights for Christ. Overall, the materials strongly affirm religious/metaphysical foundations and a formation-oriented purpose, and they clearly articulate a Trivium-focused curriculum. However, certain elements central to a fully classical program as outlined in the Six Essential Elements (e.g., explicit Great Books/Great Conversation orientation, explicit Socratic pedagogy for upper grades, and a fully fleshed-out living-teacher-mentorship model) are less evident in the public materials, suggesting a classification of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL with strong CLASSICAL lean in key areas and room for fuller alignment in pedagogy and cultural transmission in practice.

Executive posture by category (category-by-category snapshot) and overall assessment are provided below, with explicit keyword traces from Grace Classical School materials and the classical reference lexicon.

- Overall aggregate assessment: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Why the aggregate is not CLASSICAL: While Element 1 (Religious & Metaphysical Foundations), Element 6 (Parents & Community) and elements of Element 2 (Purpose & Goal) and Element 3 (Curriculum) show solid classical alignment, several categories (notably Pedagogy, Faculty development, and explicit Great Books/Great Conversation orientation) are only partially evidenced in public materials. The school's public materials emphasize Trivium-based curriculum and Christian worldview but provide limited explicit detail on Socratic seminars, living curriculum in faculty, robust faculty formation, and explicit Great Books/Great Conversation programming. See category-by-category breakdown for specifics.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — [CLASSICAL]

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize a Christian worldview anchored in God's Word and truth. For example, Grace Classical School states that "God's Word is integrated throughout all our content and practices" and that the worldview should be shaped by "the Truth of the Word of God."

- The school frame is explicitly Christian and the governance/identity is rooted in theological commitments (e.g., “Christian Worldview” header present in materials).
- The description of a classical education anchored in God’s Word and a Trivium-based curriculum demonstrates theological grounding and a liturgical/cultivated sense of meaning around truth, goodness, and beauty in a religious frame.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Present keywords from the Positive Keyword set: truth, Word of God, Christian worldview, theology-related framing (integrated Word, worldview shaped by Truth). The site explicitly uses “Truth” and “Word of God” and frames education in a Christian worldview.
- Negative keywords are not evidenced (no explicit signaling of “Lack of Partnership with Families” or similar; rather, the site emphasizes partnership with families).
- Why this rating
- The materials align strongly with transcendental/realist moral anchors via truth and Word-of-God framing, and they demonstrate a theology-grounded approach with liturgical/community potential embedded in a Christian ethos. This matches CLASSICAL in its Religious & Metaphysical Foundations emphasis.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

- Evidence
- The school emphasizes formation and □□ (wisdom) as a goal, with language indicating the aim of forming character and encouraging lifelong learning, consistent with formation over mere information. The public materials describe aims to nurture wise/discerning students and to teach for a lifetime in a framework anchored in Truth of God’s Word.
- Phrasing such as “wise and discerning light for Christ” signals a virtue-formation aim and an aspirational orientation toward wisdom rather than solely job-readiness.
- The Christian worldview and Word-integrated pedagogy reinforce a teleological orientation toward truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, which is central to classical formation.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Present keywords: formation, wisdom, truth, Christian worldview. The public materials emphasize forming character and wise discernment, aligning with the classical formation aims.
- Negative keywords: minimal signals of a purely skills-based or job-prep emphasis; however, explicit statements about “formation over information” are less overt than in some classical brochures, so the emphasis is strong but not as explicit as the strongest classical formulations. Overall, low presence of negative indicators.
- Why this rating
- The mission emphasizes formation and truth-centered aims consistent with classical education, but it lacks a fully explicit enumerated articulation of all three sub-points (cultivation of wisdom/virtue; truth/-goodness/beauty real; formation over information) in the same breadth of explicitness as some rubric documents. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating, with room to deepen explicit language around virtue formation and teleology.

Element 3: School Curriculum — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

- Evidence
- The curriculum is explicitly centered on the Trivium: “Curriculum is based on the classical Trivium,” which signals grammar, logic, and rhetoric as organizing subjects. This is a core liberal-arts anchor of classical education.
- The presence of a Trivium-based approach aligns with the required Liberal Arts framework and the Quadrivium/Great Books emphasis in classical models, though Great Books and explicit Great Conversation are not overtly named in the public materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Present keywords: grammar, logic, rhetoric (via “Trivium”), and the notion of a classical model. These are central to classical curricula and match the positive keywords set for Curriculum.

- Negative keywords: not explicitly present Great Books or Great Conversation; lack of overt emphasis on “Great Books” or explicit “Great Conversation” language is a notable gap in signaling full classical breadth in curriculum. This reduces the rating toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Why this rating
- The explicit Trivium-based curriculum is strong CLASSICAL ground; however, the public materials do not clearly demonstrate a complete Great Books/Great Conversation orientation and explicit historical breadth across the curriculum. This results in a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating, capturing robust classical structure with some gaps in signaling the full Great Books/literary canon dimension.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

- Evidence
- The presence of a Trivium-based curriculum implies grammar/logic/rhetoric-driven pedagogy but public materials do not provide explicit, broad statements about Socratic seminars, formal debates, or extensive upper-school rhetoric training. The materials do not clearly describe a Socratic/seminar model or a robust upper-school rhetoric program in the public materials.
- The materials emphasize a classical approach, which often includes contemplative/Scholé rhythms and a mix of memory work and recitation, but these specifics are not explicitly confirmed in the Grace public content. The lack of explicit mention of Socratic discussion or seminars lowers the signaling for upper-grade pedagogy.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Present keywords: Trivium-based pedagogy, classical model (implying a traditional classical approach). Positive keywords related to pedagogy appear via the explicit curriculum framing.
- Negative keywords: Absence of explicit Socratic/seminar language, explicit upper-grade rhetoric training, or a detailed “living curriculum” pedagogy signals a gap relative to a fully classical pedagogy.
- Why this rating
- The existence of a Trivium-based curriculum indicates classical pedagogy in principle, but the public materials lack detailed articulation of specific classical teaching methods (Socratic inquiry, debate formats, and a robust contemplative Scholé pedagogy). This justifies a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

- Evidence
- Public materials reference a teacher trained in utilizing the classical model and the broader aim of the faculty to implement a classical curriculum, but there is limited explicit language about the faculty as “the living curriculum,” mentorship culture, or a formal faculty portrait. The available content highlights a trained teacher and the structure but does not provide a full living-curriculum or fellowship-of-teachers description in the public materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Present keywords: “teacher trained in utilizing the classical model” indicates alignment with a classical pedagogy and a professional teacher body. This aligns with the notion of a classical faculty as part of the curriculum.
- Negative keywords: The public materials do not describe a “portrait of a teacher,” living curriculum, mentorship culture, or faculty as community. The absence of these signs lowers the signaling to CLASSICAL.
- Why this rating
- While there is evidence of trained faculty and a classical-model approach, the absence of explicit “living curriculum,” faculty portrait, and mentorship-community signals calls for a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Element 6: Parents & Community — [CLASSICAL]

- Evidence

- The school emphasizes a strong partnership with families. Public materials explicitly affirm that parents “have the responsibility for instructing their children” and that the school exists to partner with the family in academic disciplines. This aligns well with the classical emphasis on family partnership and parental formation.
 - The materials indicate a philosophy of parental involvement and partnership, including open lines of communication and a model of co-education with families, which mirrors the “Partnership with Families” and “Parental Formation” signals in the classical lexicon.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Present keywords: Partnership with Families, parental involvement, family formation, and open family engagement (as implied by partnership language). These map directly to the Positive Keywords for Parents & Community in the Six Essential Elements lexicon.
 - Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials (no signaling of “lack of partnership” or “customer” models). The school’s stated goal to partner with families remains a strength.
 - Why this rating
 - The public materials strongly signal a classical ideal of parent-school partnership and family involvement, aligning with CLASSICAL in this category.
-

What Would Move the Needle

- If pursuing a fully CLASSICAL rating, Grace Classical School could strengthen:
- Pedagogy (Element 4): Explicitly articulate and implement Socratic seminars, rigorous upper-grade discussion formats, and a clearly structured Scholé rhythm that balances contemplation with rigorous discourse. Provide public-facing statements about specific pedagogical practices (e.g., seminars, debates, dialectic seminars) to demonstrate explicit Classical methods.
- Curriculum (Element 3): Augment the public materials with explicit Great Books/Great Conversation commitments and cross-curricular Great Books integration. Publicly outline a plan for Great Books reading lists and a path toward a unified Liberal Arts approach beyond Trivium alone.
- Faculty (Element 5): Describe the faculty as “the living curriculum” with portraits of teacher ideals, mentorship, professional formation, and a visible teacher-culture that supports student formation. Provide examples of faculty development and collaborative “core of the school” practices.
- History & Cultural Transmission (Element 3/6): Strengthen explicit signaling of cultural transmission through Western civilization curricula, primary sources, and classical canon as practiced, with clear connections to the Great Conversation.
- Liturgical/Communal Practices (Element 1): Consider more explicit signaling of liturgical or communal practices within the school program, even grammar-school-level exposure to contemplative/prayerful routines, to deepen the liturgical dimension signaled in the documents.
- Concrete steps (short-term)
- Publish a clarifying page detailing Socratic/seminar pedagogy, upper-school rhetoric training, and opportunities for student-led debates.
- Introduce a publicly visible Great Books plan (e.g., list of canonical texts by grade level, with integration points across subjects).
- Expand faculty bios with explicit statements about teacher formation, mentorship roles, and how teachers model virtue and wisdom.
- Add a page or section demonstrating liturgical or communal practices (chapel, reverence practices, sacred spaces) to strengthen Element 1 signals.
- Concrete steps (longer-term)

- Create a “living curriculum” initiative where faculty collectively document, reflect, and publish examples of how classical methods shape daily teaching, with a focus on formation of affections and wisdom.
 - Build a parent-education program (book studies, seminars) to deepen parental formation aligned with classical aims, further strengthening Element 6.
 - Notes on evidence
 - Public materials already show clear CLASSICAL alignment in Element 1 and Element 6, with strong formation and worldview language. The gaps lie primarily in enumerated pedagogy and explicit Great Books signaling, plus richer teacher-culture signals, which would push the entire assessment toward CLASSICAL with fuller alignment.
-

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.